

9TH EDITION • INDIA'S LARGEST HACKATHON

Smart India Hackathon 2026

From College Desk to National Finale

The complete, visual playbook — every round, every deadline, every filter. Built for IPS Academy & your 6-member team.

226	30
PROBLEM STATEMENTS 172 Software + 54 Hardware	MINISTRIES & ORGS ISRO • DRDO • SAIL • NTRO
18	 1 Lakh
THEMES Misc • Automation • Disaster	PER WINNING TEAM + Incubation & Jobs

2026 AT A GLANCE — 4 MONTHS TO WIN

JUL SPOC Reg 31 Jul deadline	AUG 25 226 PS LIVE Start picking	SEP 4-15 INTERNAL Do or die	SEP 20 SUBMIT 500/PS cap	OCT-NOV EVALUATION National jury	DEC GRAND FINALE 36 hrs • Nodal
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INTERNAL HACKATHON IS THE REAL FILTER — 70% TEAMS DIE AT COLLEGE LEVEL. THIS GUIDE SHOWS YOU HOW TO CLEAR IT.

Prepared by **SIH26** • IPS Academy, Indore • For internal team circulation • Verify all deadlines at sih.gov.in

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How to use this guide: 1) Read Stage-by-Stage in order 2) Mark your Internal Hackathon date on page 4 3) Pick 5 PS using the filters on page 5 4) Execute the 14-day checklist on last page. Print this — stick the timeline on your wall.

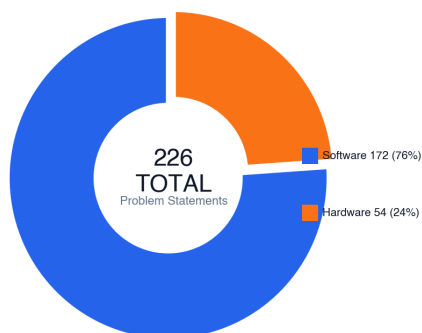
01 SIH 2026 at a Glance

India's largest open innovation model — turning students into nation-builders since 2017.

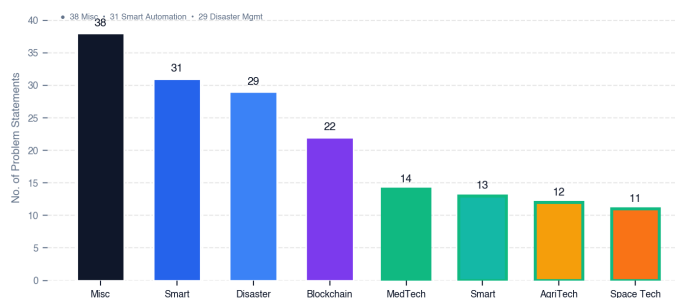
Organized by	Ministry of Education's Innovation Cell (MIC) + AICTE + 30 Ministries/PSUs
Edition	9th Edition • 2026
Problem Statements	226 Total — 172 Software (76%) + 54 Hardware (24%) • 30 Orgs • 18 Themes
Eligibility	UG/PG students from SAME college/university • Cross-department allowed • No inter-college teams
Team Size	Exactly 6 students + 1-2 mentors (faculty/industry) • ≥1 female mandatory
Mentor	1-2 faculty or industry mentors per team • Can guide multiple teams
Format	Software: 36-hour non-stop hackathon • Hardware: 5-day build at nodal center
Prize	■ 1,00,000 per winning team + Incubation, IPR support, Govt internship & job pipeline

Category & Theme Breakdown

SIH 2026 • Category Split



Theme Distribution • 18 Themes Total • Green border = Low-competition niche



Left: 3/4 are software — easier to prototype. • Right: Green borders = niche themes (MedTech, Space, AgriTech) with <15 PS — fewer competitors.

Who Gives the Problems? — Top Orgs by PS Count

Org	PS Count	What it means
AICTE	34	Most popular → HIGHEST competition • Avoid unless very strong idea
MoES (Earth Sciences)	30	Weather / Polar / Ocean — niche but data-heavy
NTRO	23	Cyber / Signals — elite, needs security depth
DoLR (Land Resources)	9	GIS / Land — LOW competition , highly winnable
ISRO	11	Space Tech — hard, but ISRO loves deployable prototypes
SAIL / MOIL / MSME	1-3 each	GEMS — 1 PS per org = <100 teams fight for it

Pro tip: Filter by org with ≤10 PS on sih.gov.in — that's where 10x lower competition hides.

02 The Big Picture — 7 Stages from College to Finale

You don't register directly on sih.gov.in. **Your college is the gatekeeper.** Here's the exact flow every team must clear:

STAGE 0 JUNE-JULY 2026	SPOC REGISTRATION Your college appoints a Single Point of Contact (faculty) & registers on sih.gov.in. No SPOC = No SIH for your entire college.
STAGE 1 25 AUG 2026	PROBLEM STATEMENTS LIVE 226 PS published (172 SW + 54 HW). SPOC 'blocks' 10-15 PS your college will compete on. You pick from BLOCKED list only.
STAGE 2 25 AUG – 6 SEP	TEAM FORMATION Form exactly 6 from SAME college (≥1 female). Cross-dept OK. Pick 1-2 mentors. Lock primary + backup PS.
STAGE 3 4 – 15 SEP 2026	INTERNAL HACKATHON College-level hackathon MANDATORY. Present PPT + prototype to internal jury. Top teams get SPOC nomination.
STAGE 4 BY 20 SEP 2026	SPOC NOMINATION & IDEA SUBMISSION SPOC uploads nominated teams' PPT + 3-min video to sih.gov.in. HARD deadline. 500 ideas/PS cap — first-come.
STAGE 5 OCT – NOV 2026	NATIONAL EVALUATION Govt + industry experts score 1,000s of ideas online. Only ~1,300 make it. Results published Oct/Nov.
STAGE 6 DEC 2026	GRAND FINALE 36-hr (SW) / 5-day (HW) at nodal centers across India. Build, demo, pitch to ministry. Winners get ■1L + incubation.

Key insight: Stages 3 + 4 are sequential bottlenecks. Fail internal = never reach national. Miss 20 Sep deadline or 500/PS cap = auto-reject even if you won internal.

03 Visual Timeline — August to December 2026

Print this. Stick on wall. Check daily.

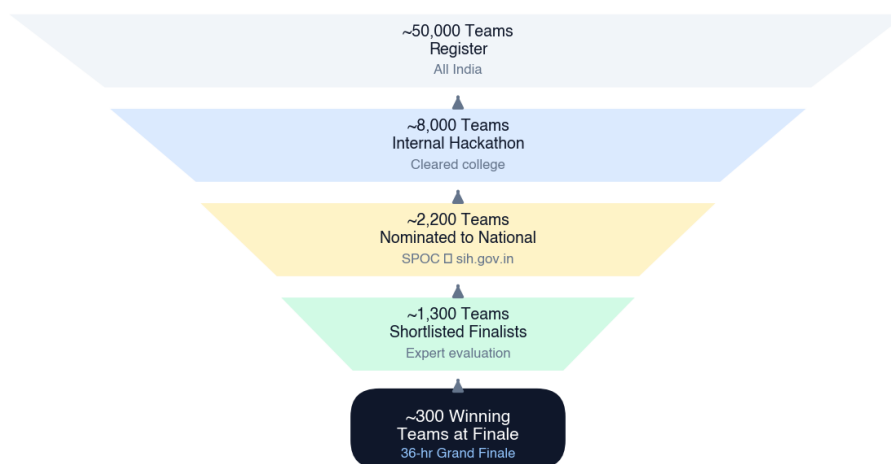
PHASE	DATES (2026)	WHAT HAPPENS	YOUR BUFFER
SPOC Reg	June – 31 July	College SPOC registers at sih.gov.in/signin . Early = get updates first.	Ask HOD now Is our SPOC done?
PS Release	25 Aug	226 PS LIVE on sih.gov.in/sih2026PS . YouTube launch. Idea counter starts.	Download CSV from GitHub mirror
Team Lock	25 Aug – 6 Sep	Form 6 (≥1 female), pick mentors, shortlist 8-10 PS → score → lock 2.	Don't wait for PS to form team
Internal Hackathon	4 – 15 Sep	COLLEGE HACKATHON — PPT + demo to internal jury. Most important filter.	WIN THIS or you're out
Internal Report	By 18 Sep	College uploads internal hackathon report + nominated teams list.	SPOC does this Track it
National Submission	BY 20 SEP 11:59 PM IST	SPOC submits your Idea PPT + video on portal. 500 ideas/PS cap — portal freezes.	Submit by 18 Sep Don't risk 500 cap

Screening	Sep – Oct	National experts evaluate PPTs online. No code yet — PPT is everything.	Refine PPT after internal feedback
Results	Oct 2026	Shortlist published on sih.gov.in . SPOC notified. Mentors assigned.	Check daily in Oct
Mentoring	Nov 2026	Online mentoring with org experts. Refine prototype. Nodal center allotted.	Attend all sessions
GRAND FINALE	Dec 2026	36 hrs SW / 5 days HW at nodal centers. Build, demo, win 1L.	Be there Travel + stay by org

Hard rules: • Only 500 ideas per PS — portal auto-freezes • Max 50 teams per institute (45 + 5 waitlist) can be nominated • 100 per university • 1 team = max 2 PS submissions

04 The Funnel — Where 96% Get Eliminated

From Registration to Winners • Where 96% get filtered



Most teams fail at INTERNAL HACKATHON @ SPOC nomination. That is your real battle.

Translation: Your college internal eliminates ~84% nationally. Many colleges see 40-80 teams fight for 5-6 SPOC slots. Winning internal is harder than winning finale in some colleges.

FILTER	WHY TEAMS FAIL	HOW TO SURVIVE
Internal Hackathon	Weak PPT, no prototype, generic idea, poor pitch	Show working demo + clear problem understanding + 1 innovation twist
500/PS Cap	Submitting popular PS late — portal frozen	Pick niche PS + submit by 18 Sep, not 20 Sep
National Screening	PPT violates 6-slide format, vague tech stack, no feasibility	Follow official IDEA PPT: Problem → Solution → Tech → Feasibility → Impact → References
Finale	PPT ≠ prototype, hardcoded demo fails live	Live demo + scalable architecture + ministry-aligned pitch

05 Stage-by-Stage — Exactly What Happens & What You Must Do

Think of this as your ops manual. Each stage has **actor**, **tasks**, **deliverables**, **evaluation**. If you miss one deliverable, you're out.

STAGE 0 SPOC Registration — College Unlocks SIH • June – 31 July 2026 • Actor: College / SPOC

What happens: Your college deposes one faculty as Single Point of Contact. SPOC creates account at sih.gov.in/signin, waits for AICTE verification, then gets portal access. Without this, no student from your college can participate — even if you have the best idea in India.

TASKS FOR YOUR TEAM

- Identify SPOC: HOD / Dean / Professor — ask Innovation Cell
- SPOC fills institute profile, verifies email, awaits approval (3-7 days)
- SPOC attends AICTE briefing & gets internal hackathon guidelines

DELIVERABLES

- SPOC login active
- College appears on SIH portal search
- Access to PS list the moment it drops

How you're evaluated: AICTE verifies college credentials only — no screening yet.

Pro tip: If your college has no SPOC by 25 July, escalate to Principal. Late SPOC = rushed internal = low win rate. IPS SPOC should block PS by 28 Aug.

STAGE 1 Problem Statements Go Live — Your Menu • 25 August 2026 • Actor: Ministry → SPOC → You

What happens: 226 PS (172 Software, 54 Hardware) across 30 orgs, 18 themes drop on sih.gov.in/sih2026PS. Each PS has ID (SIH26001...), org, theme, description, expected solution, dataset link. SPOC must 'block' / shortlist ~10-15 PS that your college will allow teams to work on. You can only pick from blocked list. Idea submission counter goes LIVE — 500 ideas per PS, first-come-first-serve, visible publicly.

TASKS FOR YOUR TEAM

- Scrape all 226 PS via mirrors ([sih-buddy](#), [GitHub CSV](#)) — don't browse manually
- Score 8-10 PS on 5 filters: Team fit, Competition, Innovation headroom, Data feasibility, Impact
- Narrow to 3 → deep research (1 paper, 1 competitor, 1 dataset check) → lock 1 primary + 1 backup

DELIVERABLES

- Shortlist sheet with scores
- Chosen PS: SIH ID + title
- Mentor buy-in on PS

How you're evaluated: Not evaluated yet — but your PS choice decides 70% of future score. Popular PS (AICTE/ 'AI proctoring') get 1,500+ hits; niche (SAIL/MOIL/MSME) get <150.

Pro tip: Don't pick top-10 most-viewed. Filter by org with ≤10 PS. That's your 10x arbitrage. Download the [GitHub CSV](#) on day 1 before mirrors lag.

STAGE 2 Team Formation — The 6 You Bet On • 25 Aug – 6 Sep 2026 • Actor: You

What happens: Exactly 6 students from **same institute** (different departments/years OK, no inter-college). ≥1 **female mandatory** — no waiver. Pick 1-2 mentors (faculty/industry). Team leader = point of contact for all portal comms. You can cross-year: 2nd year coders + final year domain expert is a classic winning combo.

TASKS FOR YOUR TEAM

- 6 roles: Leader + Tech lead + ML/AI + Frontend + Backend + Pitch/Design (overlap OK)
- Ensure female member has core role, not token — judges ask her questions
- Register team in college internal portal (if any) & align schedules for 14-day sprint

DELIVERABLES

- Team list with roles + mentor consent
- GitHub repo + Notion/Drive
- PS locked

How you're evaluated: Internal jury will score team composition — diverse skills > 6 coders. Designers + coders + planners win.

Pro tip: If you have 7 interested, split into two teams on two PS. Two lottery tickets > one. But don't thin out talent.

STAGE 3 Internal Hackathon — The Real Final Before the Final • 4 – 15 September 2026 • Actor: College Jury (3-5 faculty + industry)

What happens: Every registered college **MUST** run an internal hackathon. This is where **70% die**. You present to internal jury: PPT (5-6 slides) + prototype/demo. Jury scores on **Problem understanding, Feasibility, Innovation, Team, Presentation**. SPOC then nominates **max 50 teams per institute (45 + 5 waitlist)** and max 100 per university. If your college has 60 teams, 10-15 will be cut even if good. External colleges' internal dates vary — yours might be 4th, 10th, or 15th — confirm with SPOC NOW.

TASKS FOR YOUR TEAM

- Build minimum lovable prototype: clickable Figma + core algorithm + 2-min demo video
- Prepare official 6-slide IDEA PPT (not 20 slides): Problem, Solution, Tech, Feasibility, Impact, References
- Rehearse 3-min pitch + 5-min Q&A; — jury will poke holes

DELIVERABLES

- 6-slide PPT + demo link (video/hosted)
- Internal score sheet
- SPOC nomination (if won)

How you're evaluated: SPOC looks for: Can this be built in 36 hrs? Is it different from obvious? Does the team understand the domain? Not just slides — show you've run code / collected data.

Pro tip: Treat internal as dress rehearsal for finale. Bring working prototype while others bring slides — you'll be memorable. Show live demo, not video. Have backup PS ready if jury says 'too crowded'.

STAGE 4 SPOC Nomination & National Idea Submission — Portal Battle • By 20 Sep 2026, 11:59 PM IST

• Actor: SPOC uploads • You provide content

What happens: SPOC logs into sih.gov.in, enters nominated team details, team leader gets credentials, then uploads **Idea PPT + reports + undertakings**. Portal shows live counter: 'X / 500 ideas' per PS — once 500 hit, PS freezes permanently. **One team = max 2 PS submissions**. After upload, you cannot change PS. This is your **hard gate to nationals** — miss deadline or hit frozen PS = instant reject, no appeal.

TASKS FOR YOUR TEAM

- Finalize PPT by 17 Sep (mentor review 2 rounds)
- Record 3-min idea video (host on YouTube unlisted, link in PPT)
- SPOC uploads before 18 Sep — don't wait till 20 Sep (500 cap + server crash)

DELIVERABLES

- Submitted Idea ID on portal
- PDF of PPT + video link
- Undertaking / NOC as per guidelines

How you're evaluated: Portal checks: 6 members? 1 female? Same college? Duplicate PS? Auto-reject if violated. No evaluation yet — just eligibility.

Pro tip: At 19 Sep night, popular PS freeze. Your niche PS still open — that's why Stage 1 matters. Keep SPOC's phone on speed dial. Confirm submission got 'Submitted' status, not 'Draft'.

STAGE 5 National Evaluation — Experts Screen Thousands • September – November 2026 • Actor: MIC/AICTE +

Ministry + Industry experts

What happens: Online, paper-based. Each idea gets 2-3 reviewers (govt officials from problem-org + industry + academia). They score PPT + video only — **no repo access**. Shortlisting ~ **1,300 teams** (Software + Hardware combined) from ~6,000-8,000 nominated. Results published **October 2026** on sih.gov.in & emailed to SPOC. Waitlist moves in Nov if finalists drop. Mentoring sessions start Nov — org experts guide finalists to refine prototype.

TASKS FOR YOUR TEAM

- No action from you unless shortlisted — but keep building prototype
- If shortlisted: attend all mentoring calls, log org feedback, refine architecture
- Prepare travel docs — finale nodal centers assigned in Nov

DELIVERABLES

- Shortlist PDF on portal
- Mentor allocation letter
- Nodal center + problem mentor contact

How you're evaluated: Scoring rubric = Innovation (30) + Feasibility (20) + Tech execution (20) + Impact (15) + Presentation (15). PPT clarity & feasibility are 70% of score at this stage — you haven't coded finale yet.

Pro tip: Judges skim 50 PPTs/hour. Your PPT must pass 60-second test: title, problem, novel twist, tech stack diagram, feasibility matrix. No walls of text. One diagram > 5 bullets.

STAGE 6 Grand Finale — 36 Hours to Win ■1 Lakh • December 2026 • Actor: Ministry + SIH Central at Nodal Centers

What happens: **Software: 36-hour non-stop hackathon** (often 2 days + overnight) • **Hardware: 5 days** continuous build. Hosted at nodal centers (IITs/NITs/selected colleges) across India. You get: mentor, infra, food, stay. You build, integrate, test, and demo live to ministry. Final pitch: 10-min presentation + live demo + Q&A; from org. Winners per PS: 1 winner (■1L) + 2-3 runners, plus incubation & IPR filing support. Many solutions get Pilots / MoUs with ministry.

TASKS FOR YOUR TEAM

- Arrive day before: check infra, backup laptop, offline dataset, power bank
- Hour 0-8: Setup + core build • 8-24: Feature-complete • 24-32: Polish + test edge cases • 32-36: Pitch deck + demo script
- Live demo > slides. Handle jury's 'what if' + scalability questions

DELIVERABLES

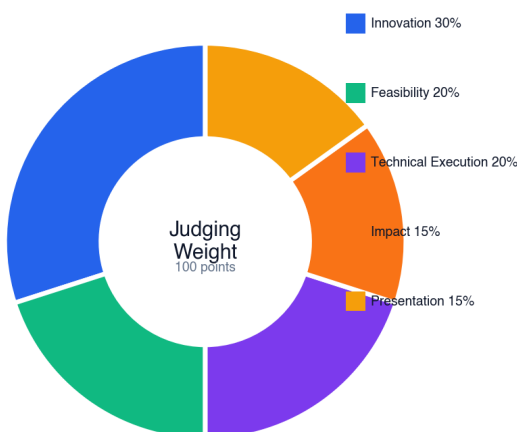
- Working prototype (deployed link + repo + video)
- Final PPT (updated from idea PPT)
- Demo to jury

How you're evaluated: Judging now is 50% prototype + 30% presentation + 20% Q&A.; Hardcoded demos get caught — jury asks to change input live. Have logs, not mocks.

Pro tip: Sleep in shifts, not zero sleep. Best teams assign 'pitcher' who doesn't code last 6 hrs — they polish story while coders finish. Bring HDMI, extension, LAN cable, offline installer — nodal WiFi is chaos.

06 How Judging Actually Works — 100-Point Decoded

How Judges Score You



Tip: Innovation + Feasibility = 50% □ Pick PS with headroom + buildable prototype

CRITERION	WEIGHT	WHAT JUDGES ASK	HOW TO ACE
Innovation	30	Is it a novel twist or just a ChatGPT wrapper? Patentable?	1 clear novelty + diagram showing difference from existing
Feasibility	20	Can 6 students build this in 36 hrs with available data?	Tech stack + data source + risk matrix + mitigation
Technical Execution	20	Does prototype work live? Architecture scalable?	Live demo + GitHub + API docs + load test
Impact & Benefit	15	Who benefits? How many? Cost saving?	Numbers: "Saves █X cr / helps Y lakh users"
Presentation	15	Is story clear, visual, timed, confident?	6-slide IDEA format + 3-min pitch + Q&A; prep

At Internal + National screening, **Feasibility + PPT clarity** carry 50% weight — you're not judged on code yet. At Finale, **prototype** takes over. Align effort accordingly.

Official 6-Slide IDEA PPT — Never Exceed 6

SLIDE	TITLE	MUST INCLUDE	TIME
1	PS & Title	PS ID, Org, Category, Theme, Team ID — crisp problem reframing	30 sec
2	Solution & Innovation	Novelty diagram vs existing, 1 wow feature, why different	60 sec
3	Technical Approach	Stack, architecture diagram, workflow, APIs, data flow	60 sec
4	Feasibility & Challenges	Risks + mitigation, data availability, hardware cost if any	30 sec
5	Impact & Future	Beneficiaries, numbers, scalability, prototype/demo link	45 sec
6	References & Research	Papers, datasets, GitHub, org contacts — proof of depth	15 sec

File: **PPTX only** • Max ~10 MB • Embed video as YouTube unlisted link • Judges will open on Windows — test fonts.

07 Winning Strategy — What 3× Evaluators Actually Score

DO — Score Points

- Pick niche PS (org with ≤10 PS) — 10x less crowd
- Show working prototype at internal — slides are forgettable
- Speak ministry language: KPIs, cost, deployment
- Validate dataset/hardware before locking PS
- Cross-year team: juniors code fast, seniors know domain
- Get 2 mentor reviews before SPOC upload
- Treat internal as finale rehearsal — time your pitch
- Build scalable story: "Pan-India, low-cost, offline-ready"

DON'T — Auto-Reject

- Popular PS with 1,500+ ideas — you're invisible
- Inter-college team — portal auto-rejects
- 0 female member — mandatory, no exception
- 7 slides / 20 slides PPT — violates 6-slide rule
- Hardcoded demo — jury changes input live & you fail
- No data proof — "we'll get data later" = 0 feasibility
- Submitting on 20 Sep 11:59 PM — portal may be frozen
- Ignoring internal feedback — SPOC knows what jury wants

“Building is easy with AI. Picking the right PS is the moat. Niche + feasible + ministry-aligned = 50% win before coding.” — SIH 2022 World Champion & 3× Evaluator

08 Your Next 14-Day Action Plan — From Today to Internal Win

Tick this with your team. One owner per row. Daily 15-min standup.

DAY	TASK	OWNER	DONE?
Day 1 TODAY	Meet SPOC: Which 10-15 PS has IPS blocked? Add SAIL/MOIL/MSME/DoLR gems if not blocked.	Leader	■
Day 1-2	Download 226 PS CSV + score 8-10 PS on 5 filters (fit / crowd / innovation / data / impact).	All	■
Day 3	Lock 3 → deep dive: 1 paper, 1 competitor, dataset sample, ministry KPI per PS. Email org contact for data.	Split 1 PS each	■
Day 4	Team decision: Primary + Backup PS. Mentor review #1 — ask “which would you fund?”	Leader + Mentor	■
Day 5-8	Build minimum prototype: core algorithm + clickable demo + architecture diagram. Not perfect — working.	Tech team	■
Day 8-9	Craft 6-slide IDEA PPT + 3-min video. Mentor review #2. Internal jury dry-run.	Pitcher + Design	■
Day 10-11	INTERNAL HACKATHON — Present, get feedback, iterate PPT overnight.	All	■
Day 12	If nominated: SPOC submits on sih.gov.in. Verify “Submitted” status + idea ID. Before 18 Sep.	Leader + SPOC	■
Day 13-14	Post-submit: refine prototype for Oct evaluation + finale. Keep building while others wait.	All	■

DEADLINE WARNING: After 20 Sep 11:59 PM IST the portal locks. No extension has been given in SIH history. 500/PS cap may lock popular PS before 20 Sep. Submit by 18 Sep with SPOC buffer. Check status = “Submitted”, not “Draft”.

Quick Links & Resources

Official Portal	sih.gov.in/sih2026PS — PS list + sih.gov.in/signin — SPOC login
Mirrors (faster filter)	sih-buddy.vercel.app • codehuntersacademy.com/sih-2026-ps • GitHub: SIH-2026-Problem-Statements
Guidelines PDF	sih.gov.in/letters/2026/SIH 2026 Guidelines.pdf — read pages 2-3 for nomination caps
IPS SPOC	Ask Innovation Cell / HOD — confirm internal date (likely 10-15 Sep) & blocked PS list
This Guide PDF	Share via WhatsApp / Drive — print timeline page for wall

Prepared for IPS Academy Indore • Share freely within your 6-member team • Not affiliated with SIH — verify dates on official portal • Built by SIH26, your hackathon co-pilot

Go win SIH 2026. See you at the nodal center in December. ■